



VOLUNTEER TOOLKITS

Volunteer Tutor Training Toolkit

Everything a new MSC tutor needs for a confident, useful first session.

You do not need a teaching degree to make a real difference for an English learner. You need patience, consistency, and a simple structure. This toolkit gives you all three.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Getting ready for your first session

- ☐ Confirm the time, place (or video link), and your learner's first name
- ☐ Ask MSC what your learner's main goal is — work, school, appointments, daily life
- ☐ Prepare one simple activity and one backup; do not over-plan
- ☐ Arrive a few minutes early and bring something to write with and on

THE SESSION

A simple 30-minute structure

- 1 Warm up (5 min).** Greet, ask how their week was, and let them talk. This lowers nerves and is itself real practice.
 - 2 Set the focus (2 min).** Name one thing you'll work on today, tied to their goal: "Let's practice calling to make an appointment."
 - 3 Practice together (15 min).** Model it once, do it together, then let them try while you support. Roleplay real situations.
 - 4 Use it for real (5 min).** Have them do it once more, as independently as they can. Praise specifics.
 - 5 Wrap up (3 min).** Recap the one thing you practiced, suggest a small task before next time, and confirm the next session.
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Culturally responsive tutoring

Do

- ☐ Let silence sit — thinking takes time in a new language
- ☐ Correct gently and selectively; pick what matters most
- ☐ Build on what your learner already knows
- ☐ Follow their goals, not a rigid curriculum
- ☐ Assume competence, always

Don't

- ☐ Correct every single error — it discourages
- ☐ Treat an accent as a problem to fix
- ☐ Speak louder instead of slower and clearer
- ☐ Fill every pause; give room to respond
- ☐ Overload a session with new material

WHEN IT HAPPENS

Handling common moments

IF...	TRY...
Your learner goes quiet	wait, then simplify the question or offer two choices to pick from.
You don't know an answer	say "Great question — let me find out and tell you next time." Honesty builds trust.
They keep making one error	note it, and gently focus one short activity on just that next session.
A session falls flat	that's normal. Consistency over weeks matters more than any single meeting.

LOGGING YOUR HOURS

After each session, record the date, length, and a one-line note on what you practiced. MSC verifies these hours for school service requirements, NHS, and similar programs.

Part of MSC volunteer onboarding. Every tutor completes this toolkit before their first session.